Anisah Bagul Amanodin-Umpa

Anisah Bagul Amanodin-Umpa (born July 10, 1961) is a Filipino jurist serving as Associate Justice of the Court of Appeals of the Philippines, appointed by President Rodrigo Duterte on April 13, 2020.

She holds the distinction of being the first Moro woman in the appellate court's eighty-four-year history to reach the bench, and only the second Moro jurist overall — after Associate Justice Japar Dimaampao, who was appointed in 2005.

A Maranao from Balindong, Lanao del Sur, she built her career from the ground up: scholarship student, *cum laude* graduate, public attorney, law professor, and decade-long Regional Trial Court judge — before earning her seat on the appellate bench.

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BACKGROUND

Anisah Bagul Amanodin was born on July 10, 1961, in Balindong, a municipality in Lanao del Sur in the highland interior of Mindanao.

Lanao del Sur sits at the geographic and cultural heart of the Bangsamoro homeland — the contiguous Muslim-majority territories of Mindanao, the Sulu Archipelago, and Palawan that anchor the Bangsamoro people's long-standing aspirations for self-determination.

She belongs to the Maranao people, one of the principal ethnolinguistic groups of Muslim Mindanao, whose name comes from the word *ranao*, meaning lake, a reference to Lake Lanao, the second largest lake in the Philippines and the spiritual center of Maranao civilization.

The Maranao are known for the *okir* decorative tradition, the *Darangen* epic poetry cycle, and an Islamic legal culture that predates Spanish colonization.

Growing up in Lanao del Sur placed her squarely in a community navigating the intersection of Islamic identity, political autonomy, and national integration — a reality shaped by decades of armed conflict, peace negotiations, and displacement that defined the Bangsamoro experience in the latter half of the twentieth century.

EDUCATION

She pursued both her undergraduate and law degrees at Mindanao State University (MSU), the flagship state university established in Marawi City in 1961 to promote education, integration, and development in Muslim Mindanao.

She earned a Bachelor of Science in Business Administration major in Accountancy, followed by a Bachelor of Laws (LL.B.) — both from MSU's main campus in Marawi City.

She graduated *cum laude* and was a full university scholar throughout her studies.

She passed the Certified Public Accountant (CPA) licensure examination in 1985, and the Philippine Bar Examination in 1991.

Her combined formation in accounting and law gave her a technical edge in cases involving commercial disputes, financial crimes, and complex documentary evidence — a

Anisah B. Amanodin-Umpa



Born
July 10, 1961 Balindong, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Ethnicity
Maranao
Religion
Islam
Education
B.S. Business Administration (Accountancy), *cum laude*, Mindanao State University Bachelor of Laws (LL.B.), Mindanao State University
Professional Qualifications
Certified Public Accountant (1985) Member of the Philippine Bar (1991)
Current Position
Associate Justice, Court of Appeals of the Philippines

professional characteristic she shares with fellow Maranao jurist Justice Japar Dimaampao, who holds credentials in both disciplines as well.

Academic Honors

- *Cum laude* graduate, Mindanao State University
- Full university scholar throughout undergraduate and law studies

Licensure and Professional Qualifications

- Certified Public Accountant (CPA), 1985
- Member of the Philippine Bar, 1991

CAREER

Academic Career

Before entering the formal justice system, Amanodin-Umpa served as a law professor at the MSU College of Law in Marawi City.

Teaching law in Marawi placed her at the crossroads of national legal doctrine and regional political consciousness — an environment keenly aware of how legal knowledge connects to identity, power, and community empowerment.

Public Attorney

She served as a Public Attorney under the Public Attorney's Office (PAO), the government legal aid agency mandated to provide free legal representation to indigent citizens who cannot afford private counsel.

Her work as a public defender put her in direct contact with the most economically vulnerable litigants in a region where poverty, dispossession, and armed conflict had long made access to justice difficult.

Appointed by
President Rodrigo Duterte (April 13, 2020)
Oath of Office
December 22, 2020 Before Associate Justice Rodil Zalameda, Supreme Court of the Philippines
Previous Roles
Law Professor, MSU College of Law Public Attorney, Public Attorney's Office Clerk of Court V, Municipal Trial Court, Iligan City (2001) Judge, RTC Branch 2, Iligan City (2009–2020)
Institutional Affiliation
Adviser, Philippine Muslim Judges Association (PMJA)
Notability
First Moro woman appointed to the Court of Appeals of the Philippines (2020); second Moro jurist on the appellate bench overall, after Justice Japar Dimaampao (2005)
Known For
Historic appellate appointment; dual expertise in law and accountancy; long career in public legal service; adviser to the Philippine Muslim Judges Association; symbol of Bangsamoro representation in the national judiciary
Pull Quote
"Her appointment is a historic milestone for Muslim Filipino women nationwide." — Jun Alonto Datu Ramos, NCMF Bureau Director for External Relations, December 22, 2020

Clerk of Court

In 2001, she was appointed Clerk of Court V at the Municipal Trial Court in Iligan City, an administrative role overseeing docket management, procedural compliance, and court records integrity.

This posting built the procedural discipline and institutional familiarity that would later inform her temperament on the bench.

Regional Trial Court Judge

In 2009, she was appointed Judge of Regional Trial Court Branch 2 in Iligan City, a position she held for over a decade until her elevation to the Court of Appeals in 2020.

Trial judges at the RTC level carry first-instance adjudication responsibilities spanning serious criminal and civil cases, requiring sustained competence in fact-finding, evidentiary evaluation, witness credibility assessment, and discretionary legal rulings.

A decade at this level was formative.

Court of Appeals

On April 13, 2020, President Rodrigo Duterte signed the appointment paper naming Amanodin-Umpa Associate Justice of the Court of Appeals, filling the vacancy left by Justice Henri Jean Paul Inting, who had been elevated to the Supreme Court of the Philippines on May 29, 2019.

Her appointment followed the constitutional screening process of the Judicial and Bar Council (JBC), the body mandated under Article VIII of the 1987 Philippine Constitution to evaluate and recommend judicial nominees.

Her appointment paper was transmitted to the Supreme Court's Office of the Clerk of Court En Banc on December 22, 2020, and she took her oath of office that same afternoon before Supreme Court Associate Justice Rodil Zalameda.

The roughly eight-month gap between the signing of her appointment and her oath-taking — coinciding with the COVID-19 pandemic — has not been formally explained.

The Court of Appeals of the Philippines, established in 1936, serves as the intermediate appellate tribunal of the Philippine judicial system, reviewing decisions of Regional Trial Courts and various quasi-judicial agencies. It comprises 69 justices organized into 23 divisions, with the last three divisions based in Cagayan de Oro City.

HISTORIC SIGNIFICANCE

First Moro Woman on the Court of Appeals

Her oath-taking on December 22, 2020 marked the first time in the Court of Appeals' eighty-four-year history that a Moro woman had been appointed to the appellate bench.

She is the second Moro jurist on the CA overall, after Associate Justice Japar Dimaampao of Marawi City — also a Maranao — who was appointed in 2005.

Her appointment was publicly announced by Jun Alonto Datu Ramos, NCMF Bureau Director for External Relations, who called it a historic milestone for Muslim Filipino women nationwide.

Intersectional Representation

Her appointment represents intersectional visibility across three historically underrepresented categories in the Philippine national judiciary:

- **Regional** — representing Mindanao and the Bangsamoro homeland
- **Religious** — as a Muslim jurist within a predominantly Christian institutional context
- **Gender** — as the first Moro woman on the appellate bench

Timing within the Bangsamoro Transition

Her elevation came just one year after the formal establishment of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) in 2019, itself the product of the Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro signed in 2014 between the Government of the Philippines and the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF).

While judicial appointments are constitutionally insulated from direct political influence through the JBC process, the timing of her oath-taking in the early implementation phase of the Bangsamoro peace settlement gave her appointment additional resonance within the broader post-conflict normalization effort.

JURISPRUDENCE AND INSTITUTIONAL CONTRIBUTIONS

Appellate Jurisprudence

Since assuming office, Justice Amanodin-Umpa has participated in appellate decisions spanning criminal procedure, civil liability, administrative review, and labor disputes.

Her decade on the trial bench has sharpened her appellate scrutiny — particularly in evaluating whether lower courts correctly applied the proof-beyond-reasonable-doubt standard in criminal proceedings.

Her dual training in accounting and law gives her particular facility in cases involving financial crimes, commercial fraud, documentary evidence analysis, and forensic accounting — competencies of growing importance at the appellate level.

Muslim Personal Law and the Plural Legal System

The Philippines maintains a parallel legal structure through Presidential Decree No. 1083 — the Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines — which grants Shari'ah courts jurisdiction over personal and family matters involving Muslim parties.

The Court of Appeals exercises supervisory and review jurisdiction over procedural questions arising from Shari'ah court proceedings.

Justice Amanodin-Umpa's cultural formation and legal training provide interpretive grounding in cases that intersect with Muslim personal law contexts.

Philippine Muslim Judges Association

Justice Amanodin-Umpa serves as an adviser to the Philippine Muslim Judges Association (PMJA), an organization whose formation was approved and supported by the Supreme Court of the Philippines in 2024.

Together with CA Associate Justice Ronald Suva Tolentino, she advises an organization working to strengthen the coherence of Muslim judicial practice across the country's Shari'ah court infrastructure.

This institutional role extends her influence well beyond her division's formal docket.

PUBLIC AND COMMUNITY RECEPTION

The announcement of her historic oath-taking drew strong response from Bangsamoro communities and Muslim Filipino networks nationwide.

Lanao del Sur Governor Mamintal "Bombit" Alonto Adiong Jr. issued a formal congratulatory message describing her achievement as proof of Maranao excellence in national institutional life.

The Bangsamoro Parliament formalized the community's recognition through an official resolution commending Justice Amanodin-Umpa for her appointment, framing it as a milestone for Moro representation in national institutions and a signal to young Bangsamoro professionals — especially women — that the national judiciary is not a closed system.

Media coverage from MindaNews and The Manila Times emphasized the historic character of her appointment and its significance for Muslim Filipino women in professional and public life.

LEGACY

Justice Amanodin-Umpa's career arc — from scholarship student and *cum laude* graduate, to public attorney, law professor, court administrator, RTC judge, and finally Associate Justice of the Court of Appeals — is a multi-decade institutional ascent built on demonstrated professional merit, not exception or accident.

Her emerging legacy takes shape across three dimensions:

- **Institutional Legacy** — She established precedent for the advancement of Moro women to the Philippine appellate bench, expanding what is structurally possible for future generations of Muslim Filipina legal professionals.
- **Doctrinal Legacy** — Her contributions to procedural clarity, evidentiary standards, and interpretive awareness at the appellate level — particularly in cases touching on Muslim personal law — strengthen the coherence of the Philippine plural legal system.
- **Social Legacy** — For young women across the Bangsamoro homeland, she is living proof that national institutions of consequence are reachable for those who pursue excellence with persistence.

Her presence on the appellate bench also contributes to what post-conflict transition scholarship calls *elite integration* — the incorporation of representatives from historically marginalized communities into national institutions of authority, a structural condition identified in peace-building literature as supportive of durable reconciliation.

PERSONAL LIFE

Justice Anisah B. Amanodin-Umpa is a native of Balindong, Lanao del Sur and a practicing Muslim.

Her surname reflects the Maranao tradition of combining family lineage identifiers.

She is known among peers and community members for her composed and dignified bearing, qualities consistent with the values of scholarship and public service that define her professional life.

SEE ALSO

- Court of Appeals of the Philippines
- Japar Dimaampao — First Moro jurist on the Court of Appeals (2005)
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines
- Judicial and Bar Council
- Mindanao State University
- Maranao people
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro

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EXTERNAL LINKS

- Court of Appeals of the Philippines — Official Website (https://ca.judiciary.gov.ph/)
- Bangsamoro Parliament — Official Website (https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/)
- Mindanao State University — Official Website (https://www.msumain.edu.ph/)
- MindaNews: Original Report on Her Historic Appointment (December 23, 2020) (https://mindanews.com/top-stories/2020/12/anisah-amanodin-umpa-1st-moro-woman-associate-justice-in-84-year-old-court-of-appeals/)

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